



DECISIVE MOMENT October 28, 312 CE

Battle of Milvian Bridge

In 312 CE, bitter rivals Constantine the Great and Maxentius met in battle outside Rome. Much was at stake, but foremost was the struggle for leadership of the western Roman Empire. Constantine went into the fray inspired by his Christian beliefs, while Maxentius put faith in pagan gods. The outcome was a turning point in the rise of Christianity.

In October 312 CE, Maxentius was making preparations behind Rome's walls to withstand a siege by Constantine. Previously, the two had separately been proclaimed emperor. Maxentius, being in Rome and having senate backing, perhaps had more legitimacy, but Constantine planned to take the city and claim the western empire as his alone.

Despite capturing some Maxentian strongholds as he crossed Italy that summer, Constantine must have felt some misgivings heading south from Gaul (France). He had a much smaller army than Maxentius, and its strength lay in a mobile cavalry that performed best in the open. However, before the battle, he apparently experienced a religious "conversion," which he may have felt put the Christian God on his side. Accounts include visions of a flaming cross in the sky and orders to place Christian symbols on his soldiers' shields.

As the battle began, Maxentius, fighting in the name of Mars, the Roman god of war, emerged into the open, giving Constantine the advantage. Maxentius had already dismantled Milvian Bridge to halt his

opponent, so he and his troops had to cross the Tiber River using a bridge made from boats. In the ensuing battle, Constantine's cavalry disrupted enemy ranks with expert charges. Maxentius's troops had nowhere to go but into the Tiber, where many, including their leader, drowned. The next day, a triumphant procession, led by Constantine, marched through Rome with Maxentius's head on a spear.

Some view Constantine's "conversion" with cynicism, but he may have seen his victory at Milvian Bridge as a symbol of the power of Christianity. The influence of the faith had been gathering pace for three centuries, assisted by imperial edicts of religious tolerance. A few months after the battle, Constantine issued the Edict of Milan, which returned confiscated property to Christians and increased their status and political standing. His Christian leanings and massive church-building program helped the religion gain a hold in the west, shaping Byzantine culture (see pp.198–99), the Eastern Orthodox church, and medieval Christian society.

Fighting for Empire

This 16th-century fresco from the Vatican depicts the events at Milvian Bridge. In the center, the brightly lit Constantine can be seen pushing Maxentius and his troops into the Tiber River. Imperial standards bear crosses and, in the sky above, angels join in the battle.

"...he saw... a cross of light... bearing the inscription, 'conquer by this'."

EUSEBIUS OF NICOMEDIA, BISHOP, 4TH CENTURY CE